

HIST 115

Modern World History

Empire, industry, migration, revolution, and global connection since 1750

FALL 2026 | AUGUST 24 - DECEMBER 18

Instructor	Jordan Taylor, MA
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Class meetings	Monday and Wednesday, 11:00 AM-12:15 PM
Location	Humanities House 101
Office hours	Mon 12:00-1:30 PM; Wed 3:00-4:30 PM; virtual appointments available
Credits	3 semester credits
Prerequisites	None; college-level reading and writing recommended

Course description

HIST 115 traces the making of the modern world from the late eighteenth century to the present. Rather than treating regions as isolated stories, the course follows movements of people, commodities, ideas, technologies, and power across borders. Students practice historical argument through maps, primary sources, comparative essays, and a small digital exhibit built around a focused question.

Learning outcomes

- Place major transformations since 1750 in chronological and geographic context.
- Analyze primary sources for authorship, audience, purpose, context, and silence.
- Compare how industrialization, empire, nationalism, and decolonization unfolded across regions.
- Construct historical arguments supported by specific, appropriately cited evidence.
- Curate a responsible public-facing interpretation of historical sources.

This syllabus is a course roadmap. Dates may shift if campus operations or class learning needs require a change; any revision will be announced in class and in the learning portal.

Materials and learning tools

- Strayer and Nelson, *Ways of the World: A Brief Global History with Sources*, volume 2. Any recent edition is acceptable; chapter numbers will be cross-listed online.
- HIST 115 Digital Sourcebook, provided at no cost through the learning portal.
- Access to a word processor and the university's ArcLight digital exhibit platform. Campus computers are available in the library.
- A citation manager is recommended but not required. Course examples use Chicago notes and bibliography style.

How your grade is calculated

Category	Weight / points	What it measures
Primary Source Annotations (6)	180 pts	Context, close reading, and responsible inference; 30 points each.
Spatial History Maps (3)	120 pts	Annotated maps showing movement, power, and connection; 40 points each.
Comparative Essays (2)	350 pts	Evidence-based arguments across regions or cases; 175 points each.
Digital Exhibit Project	250 pts	Proposal, curated source set, and public-facing final exhibit.
Seminar Preparation	100 pts	Discussion notes, workshops, and constructive peer response.

Grade scale

A = 930-1000 | A- = 900-929 | B+ = 870-899 | B = 830-869 | B- = 800-829 | C+ = 770-799 | C = 730-769 | C- = 700-729 | D = 600-699 | F = below 600

Major assignment expectations

Primary source annotations

Six 600-word annotations introduce a source, identify its audience and purpose, analyze two specific features, and explain what the source cannot tell us. Students choose from letters, speeches, photographs, advertisements, oral histories, and political documents.

Spatial history maps

Three maps visualize a historical process rather than simply label places. Each map must include a legend, date range, at least five evidence-based annotations, source credits, and a 250-word interpretive caption.

Comparative essays

Two 1,500-1,800 word essays answer a focused comparative question. Essay 1 compares industrial or imperial transformations; Essay 2 compares decolonization, development, or memory. Each uses course readings plus at least four primary sources.

Digital exhibit project

Students curate a six-item digital exhibit around a narrow historical question. The exhibit includes a proposal, a vetted source set with rights information, a 700-word framing essay, item labels, citations, alt text, and a brief curator reflection.

Assignment calendar

All dates below are firm unless the instructor announces a change. Submission times use Pacific Time. The recurring due-day pattern is shown explicitly so students can plan ahead.

Assignment	Type	Due	Pts
Primary Source Annotation 1: Revolutionary Claims	Source analysis	Fri, Sep 4 11:59 PM	30
Spatial History Map 1: Atlantic Revolutions	Map	Mon, Sep 14 11:59 PM	40
Primary Source Annotation 2: Factory Testimony	Source analysis	Fri, Sep 18 11:59 PM	30
Digital Exhibit Proposal	Project milestone	Mon, Sep 28 11:59 PM	50
Primary Source Annotation 3: Imperial Advertisement	Source analysis	Fri, Oct 2 11:59 PM	30
Spatial History Map 2: Commodity and Empire	Map	Mon, Oct 12 11:59 PM	40
Comparative Essay 1: Industry and Social Change	Essay	Fri, Oct 16 11:59 PM	175
Primary Source Annotation 4: Wartime Letter	Source analysis	Fri, Oct 23 11:59 PM	30
Digital Exhibit Curated Source Set	Project milestone	Fri, Oct 30 11:59 PM	50
Primary Source Annotation 5: Anticolonial Speech	Source analysis	Fri, Nov 6 11:59 PM	30
Spatial History Map 3: Migration after 1945	Map	Mon, Nov 16 11:59 PM	40
Comparative Essay 2: Decolonization Choices	Essay	Mon, Nov 30 11:59 PM	175
Primary Source Annotation 6: Memory and Testimony	Source analysis	Fri, Dec 4 11:59 PM	30
Final Digital Exhibit	Final project	Fri, Dec 11 11:59 PM	150

Submission checklist

Before submitting: confirm the correct file opened, include your name and course code, cite borrowed ideas, and retain a local copy. A portal timestamp is the official submission time.

Course policies and support

Reading and discussion rhythm

Short preparation notes are expected before Monday and Wednesday meetings. Major writing and project milestones are due Mondays or Fridays, leaving class meetings available for source practice and workshops. Discussion credit emphasizes preparation, listening, evidence, and the willingness to revise an interpretation.

Late work and revision

Source annotations and maps may be submitted within 72 hours for up to a 10% deduction. Comparative essays submitted late lose 5% per day for five days. Each comparative essay may be revised once within two weeks of feedback; the revision replaces the original grade when accompanied by a change memo.

Citation and historical integrity

Ideas, wording, images, data, and interpretations from others require attribution. Primary sources must be represented in context; do not alter quotations or crop images in a misleading way. If a source's creator, date, or rights status is uncertain, state the uncertainty instead of guessing.

Generative AI

AI may be used to generate search synonyms, test whether a thesis is understandable, or identify passages that need clarification. It may not select evidence, write source annotations, produce essay paragraphs, invent citations, or generate exhibit labels. Any permitted use must be disclosed in a process note and independently verified against course materials.

Inclusive historical inquiry

The course examines violence, racism, colonialism, war, displacement, and contested memory. Advance notices will identify especially graphic material. Students may step out briefly when needed and should speak with the instructor about access alternatives. Debate should challenge claims with evidence without treating classmates' identities as debate topics.

Accessibility and student support

Access and Inclusion Services coordinates accommodations. Students are welcome to discuss reading load, document accessibility, presentation format, or barriers to participation. The Writing Center, librarians, Counseling Services, and Student Care Network provide confidential support throughout the term.

Weekly course schedule

Complete assigned preparation before the first meeting listed for the week. Due items are repeated here as a planning aid; the assignment calendar remains the authoritative list.

Week	Dates	Focus and preparation	Due this week
1	Aug 24-28	Course maps and timelines; what makes a history global? Source lab: context and corroboration.	Source practice (Fri)
2	Aug 31-Sep 4	Atlantic revolutions; rights, slavery, citizenship, and competing political claims.	Annotation 1 (Fri)
3	Sep 7-11	No Monday class; Haitian Revolution and the limits of universalism; mapping workshop.	Map workshop (Fri)
4	Sep 14-18	Industrialization in Britain, Japan, and India; labor, gender, and urban change.	Map 1 (Mon); Annotation 2 (Fri)
5	Sep 21-25	Nation, state, and belonging; unification, settler expansion, and minority politics.	Exhibit question clinic (Fri)
6	Sep 28-Oct 2	New imperialism; commodity chains; race and the civilizing mission.	Exhibit Proposal (Mon); Annotation 3 (Fri)
7	Oct 5-9	Colonial rule and resistance in Africa and Asia; comparative evidence workshop.	Essay planning memo (Fri)
8	Oct 12-16	Industrial and imperial comparison; writing causal arguments.	Map 2 (Mon); Essay 1 (Fri)
9	Oct 19-23	World War I as a global conflict; mobilization, empire, and mass violence.	Annotation 4 (Fri)
10	Oct 26-30	Revolution and interwar alternatives; Soviet, fascist, and anticolonial projects.	Curated Source Set (Fri)
11	Nov 2-6	World War II in Europe and Asia; occupation, genocide, and civilian experience.	Annotation 5 (Fri)
12	Nov 9-13	Decolonization strategies; India, Algeria, Ghana, and Indonesia.	Map draft review (Fri)
13	Nov 16-20	Cold War worlds; development, nonalignment, and migration.	Map 3 (Mon)
14	Nov 23-27	No Wednesday class; independent comparative essay and exhibit studio.	Essay conference materials (Mon)
15	Nov 30-Dec 4	Globalization, memory, and human rights; oral history and testimony.	Essay 2 (Mon); Annotation 6 (Fri)
16	Dec 7-11	Digital exhibit showcase; course synthesis and contested futures.	Final Exhibit (Fri)

End-of-term reminder

Plan backward from the final due date, use office hours before a deadline becomes urgent, and contact the instructor early when circumstances interfere with your work. Asking for clarification is part of successful course participation.